with enthusiasm' writes Catherine Asher, for it was the largest mosque ever built by a non-imperial patron.

During the Nauroz festival at the court at Lahore, meanwhile, the amirs jostled to outdo each other in the extravagance of their presents, with one courtier giving Akbar a present 'worth at least 500,000 crowns'.

It was at about this time that Akbar brought in the dual rank of zat and sawar for mansabdars. Bowing to the reality that the mansabdars never did keep the complete muster required by their mansab, Akbar allowed for both the stipulated, as well as a lesser number. The zat rank corresponded to the personal pay and status of a nobleman, and the sawar rank was the actual number of horsemen he needed to maintain. So a mansabdar of 5,000 zat and 2,500 sawar had a rank of 5,000 but was actually only required to maintain 2,500 horsemen. Only Mughal and Rajput noblemen were allowed to employ horsemen solely from their own ethnic group. All others were required to keep mixed contingents. The high-ranked noblemen were paid generously and men came from across the empire, and from overseas, to try and obtain the best posts. At the turn of the seventeenth century, according to French missionary Pierre du Jarric, there were 2,941 mansabdars holding ranks from 10 to 5,000. Of these, some 150 noblemen held ranks of 2,500 or above, and these were the men, carefully selected for their talent and skill, who held all the important military and civil posts.

It was at this time that Akbar encouraged the Jesuits to build a church, though when the Jesuits asked for a written order to the effect, the Padshah answered with sudden sharpness that he himself was a living document and so his word was sufficient. According to the astounded Fathers, Akbar had 'banished the sect of Mahomet from this country; so that in the town of Lahore there is not now a single mosque'. Every Friday, he 'has brought before him forty or fifty boars which are provoked to fight with one another; and he has their tusks mounted in gold'. Badauni had despaired that 'ceasing to consider swine and dogs as unclean, he kept them in the haram and under the fort'. Akbar had brought in these many innovations in his spirit of reasoning, attempting to demonstrate the irrationality of blind beliefs. But to orthodox Muslims, these would have been horrifying and deeply disturbing trends.

One day in March of 1596, the Jesuits looked across the Ravi from their riverside residence and were alarmed to see a dishevelled congregation of yogis on the opposite bank, huddled in groups of ten and twenty to keep